ERA 1

Indigenous America

The Peopling of the Americas — to 1491

Pre-Columbian societies · environment · culture

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did geography and environment shape the distinct societies of North America before European contact?

KEY TERMS

Maize · Bering Strait · Cahokia · Iroquois Confederacy · Three Sisters · matrilineal kinship

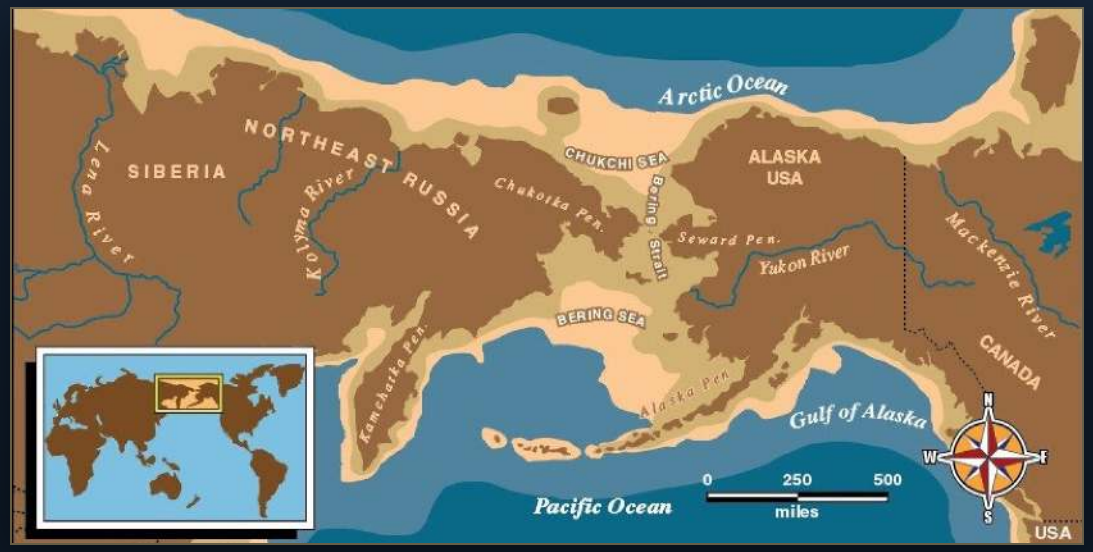
ALIGNED TO

CED Topics 1.1–1.2 · AMSCO Ch. 1.1–1.2

ONE LAND, MANY PEOPLES

Peopling a Continent

The First Migrations



- During the Ice Age, hunters crossed the **Bering Strait Land Bridge** from Asia—roughly 11,000+ years ago.
- Over millennia, peoples spread across the vast expanse of the Americas.
- They developed **distinct, increasingly complex societies**—not one culture, but hundreds.

Why So Different? Environment Shapes Society

START

Environment

Climate, terrain, and resources differ sharply across the continent.

→

THEN

Economy

Each society develops farming, hunting, or fishing to fit its land.

→

RESULT

Distinct Societies

Different economies produce different social and political systems.

THE GREAT EMPIRES

Mesoamerica & the Andes

The Aztecs (Mexica)



- Built a powerful **tribute empire** in central Mexico with a capital, **Tenochtitlan**, of 200,000+.
- An economy rooted in **maize** and intensive farming.
- A stratified society with priests, warriors, and a demanding religion of human sacrifice.

The Inca

- Created the largest **empire** in the Americas—2,000 miles along the Andes.
- United by a single ruler, a vast network of paved roads, and terrace farming.
- A complex administrative state managing millions of people.



SECTION

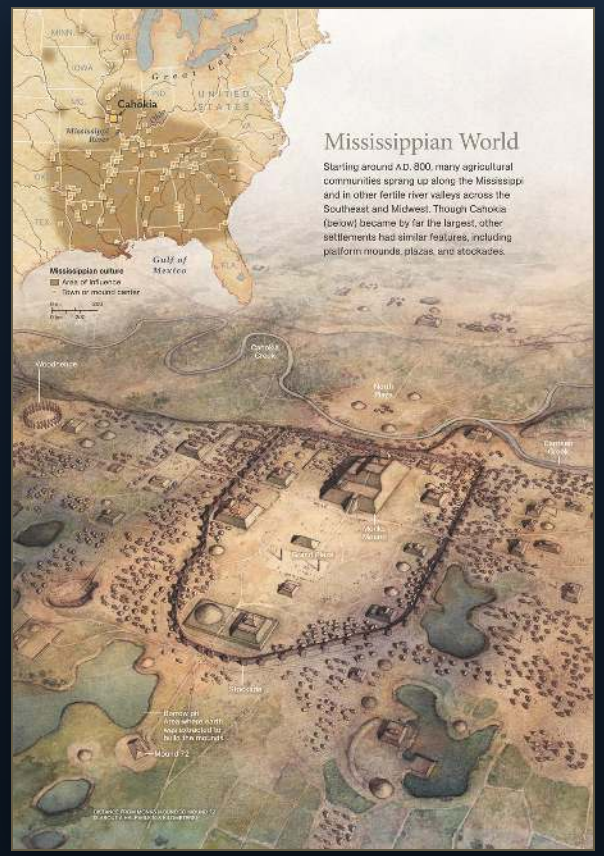
Societies of North America

Peoples of North America

Different environments → different ways of life

PEOPLE · REGION	ENVIRONMENT	ECONOMY	SOCIETY & GOVERNMENT
Mississippian · SE	Fertile river valleys	**Maize** farming; trade hub at **Cahokia**	Hierarchical **chiefdom**; mound cities
Iroquois · NE	Woodlands, rivers, lakes	**Three Sisters** farming & hunting	**Matrilineal**; **Iroquois Confederacy**
Pueblo · SW	Arid desert	Irrigation & **Three Sisters** farming	Settled adobe towns
Great Plains	Open grasslands	**Nomadic buffalo** hunting	Small, mobile bands
Pacific NW & California	Coasts, rivers, forests	Fishing (**salmon**) & gathering	Permanent villages; **potlatch**

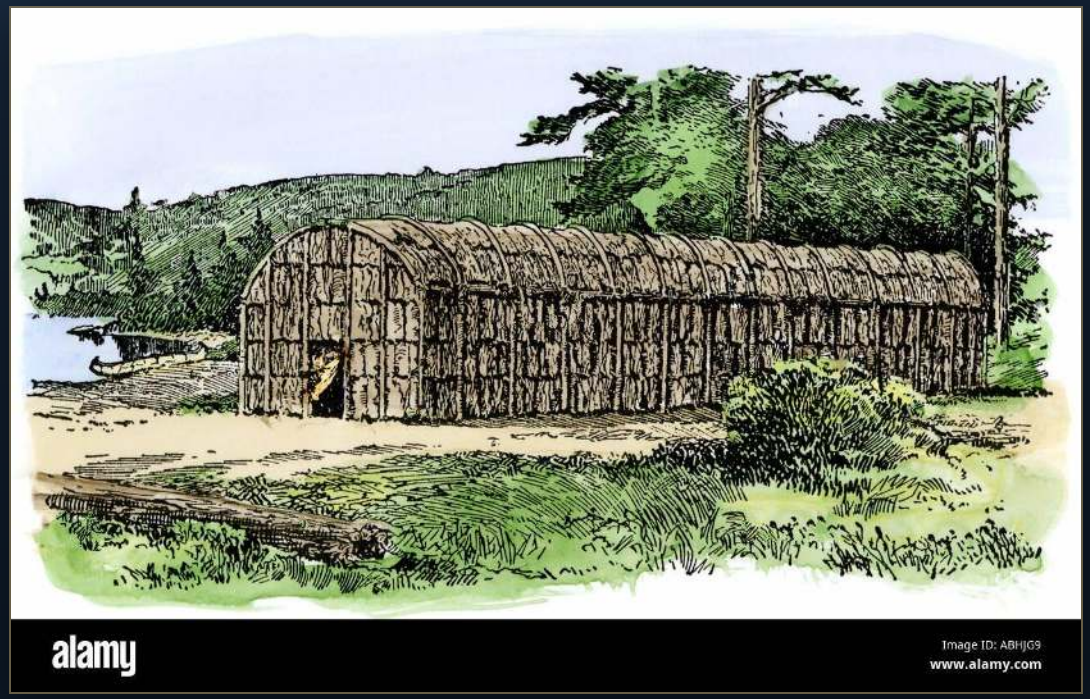
The Mississippians



- Built the largest city north of Mexico—**Cahokia**—with tens of thousands of people.
- Massive earthen mounds anchored a **maize**-based economy and trade network.
- Organized as a **chiefdom** with a clear social hierarchy.

The Iroquois

- Lived in the northeastern woodlands in large, multi-family **longhouses**.
- A **matrilineal** society—status and property traced through women.
- United rival nations under the **Iroquois Confederacy**, a lasting political alliance.



The Pueblo



- Adapted to the arid **Southwest** with advanced irrigation.
- Practiced **Three Sisters** farming—corn, beans, and squash together.
- Built permanent, multi-story towns of adobe (sun-dried brick).

The Great Plains Peoples

- Lived on open grasslands with few rivers or forests.
- Followed a **nomadic** life centered on hunting the **buffalo**.
- Organized in small, mobile bands that could move with the herds.



The Pacific Northwest & California

I

An Abundant Coast

Rich coasts, rivers, and forests provided salmon, game, and acorns.

II

No Need to Farm

Plentiful food let peoples thrive as hunter-gatherers—without agriculture.

III

Complex Villages

They built permanent, populous villages (like the Chinook) and marked status through the **potlatch**.

How Maize Transformed a Continent

ORIGIN

Mesoamerica

Maize (corn) is domesticated in present-day Mexico.

→

SPREAD

Moves North

Maize cultivation spreads into the Southwest and beyond.

→

RESULT

Settled Life

Reliable food supports permanent villages, population growth, and complex societies.

Remembering & Building

TERM

Oral tradition

Most Native societies kept their history, laws and religious beliefs alive through spoken stories, songs and ceremonies rather than written records. That is why much of what we know comes from archaeology and from later accounts.

PLACE & EVENT

Mesa Verde cliff dwellings (1190s)

Ancestral Pueblo peoples began building multistory stone homes into the cliffs of Mesa Verde (present-day Colorado) in the late 1190s. Most were abandoned by about 1300, during a period of severe drought.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Indigenous America

1. Peoples migrating across North America developed **distinct, increasingly complex societies** by adapting to and transforming their environments.

2. **Geography shaped everything**—**maize** farmers built cities and chiefdoms, Plains peoples followed the **buffalo**, and Pacific peoples thrived by fishing.

3. Long before 1492, the Americas held **millions of people** in hundreds of diverse, sophisticated societies.

DISCUSS & APPLY

Indigenous America

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

COMPARISON

Compare two societies from today (e.g., the Aztecs and the Iroquois). How did their **environments** produce different economic and political systems?

CAUSATION

Explain how the natural environment **caused** ONE society to organize its economy, government, or culture the way it did.

CONTEXTUALIZATION

What developments across the Americas **before 1491** set the stage for the changes Europeans would soon bring?

Up next — **Lesson 2: Contact & Colonization** (European exploration & the Columbian Exchange)